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Bharti's dramatic verse ***Andha Yug*** (The Blind Age), based on the epic Mahabharata. Originally written as a radio drama, it was set against the backdrop of the Second World War and its horrors. Published in 1954, *Andha Yug* is a living document of post-war despair, frustration and disbelief directed against the Divine. Not a coincidence that Samuel Beckett's *Waiting for Godot*, originally written in French in that same post-war air of 1948-49, is based on a similar theme—while vastly different as a piece of theatre. One portrays the death of God, the other waits in despair for the Unknown, perhaps the Divine, who never arrives.

When discussing the eternal essence of storytelling, Mohan Rakesh's ***Ashadh Ka Ek Din*** (One Day in Ashadh), written and published in 1958, unfailingly comes to mind. For an artist, the choice between art and power is ever-present. That internal conflict has not been etched out more forcefully in contemporary theatre than through this play's protagonist, the poet Kalidas, his vital selfhood eviscerated in distant Ujjain, separated from his first love.

Rakesh's *Adhe Adhure* (Halfway House), written in 1969, may not have aged well. But the relevance of *Ashadh Ka Ek Din*, which Rakesh based on an interpretive reading of Kalidas's *Meghadootam* as revealing of the poet's own inner turmoil, will never dim...it's one of those pieces of art that's contemporary forever.

Girish Karnad's ***Tughlaq*** (1964) presents the tragedy of a quixotic but pragmatic ruler growing unsuccessful, and, ultimately, lonely. Written originally in Kannada, it was first performed in Hindustani, after which the whole language spectrum opened up—and has still not closed.

Leave aside historical characters. If one were to consider a contemporary character, one who in fact trawls its subconscious underground, perhaps nothing could better Vijay Tendulkar's 1972 Marathi play ***Sakharam Binder*** (Sakharam the Binder). For the first time in Indian theatre, a character emerges who's so utterly unabashed, fearless and limitless that society could not digest it. The play was banned, though the tedious legal case concluded with art emerging victorious. A 2020 rendition titled *Sex, Morality and Censorship* reprised this entire episode.

THOUGH THEY'RE VERY DIFFERENT, *ANDHA YUG* HAS A KINSHIP OF MOOD WITH *WAITING FOR GODOT*. THE SAME POST-WAR DESPAIR PERMEATES BOTH

Badal Sircar's 1963 Bangla play ***Ebong Indrajit*** (And Indrajit) will easily speak to audiences in the 21st century. Though it portrays the pain of the generation born around Independence that found itself adrift in a life of futility, trying to make some semblance of sense in life, doing